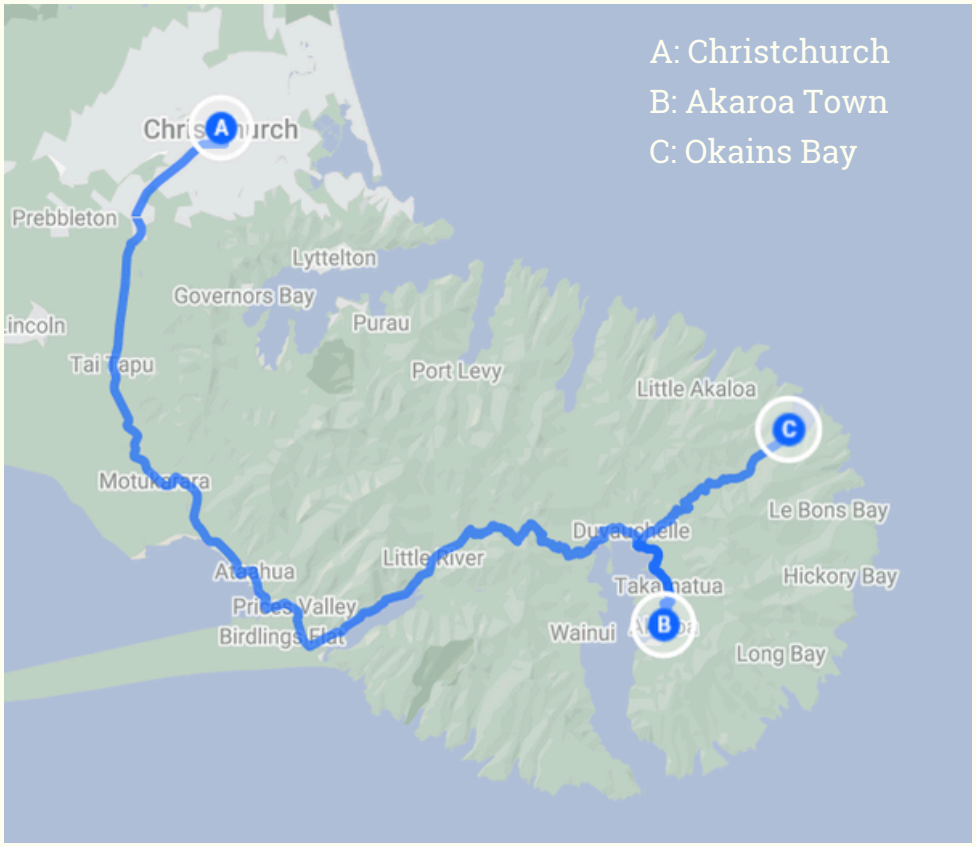


14 DAY SOUTH ISLAND ITINERARY

by Abigail Hannah

DAY 1: CHRISTCHURCH

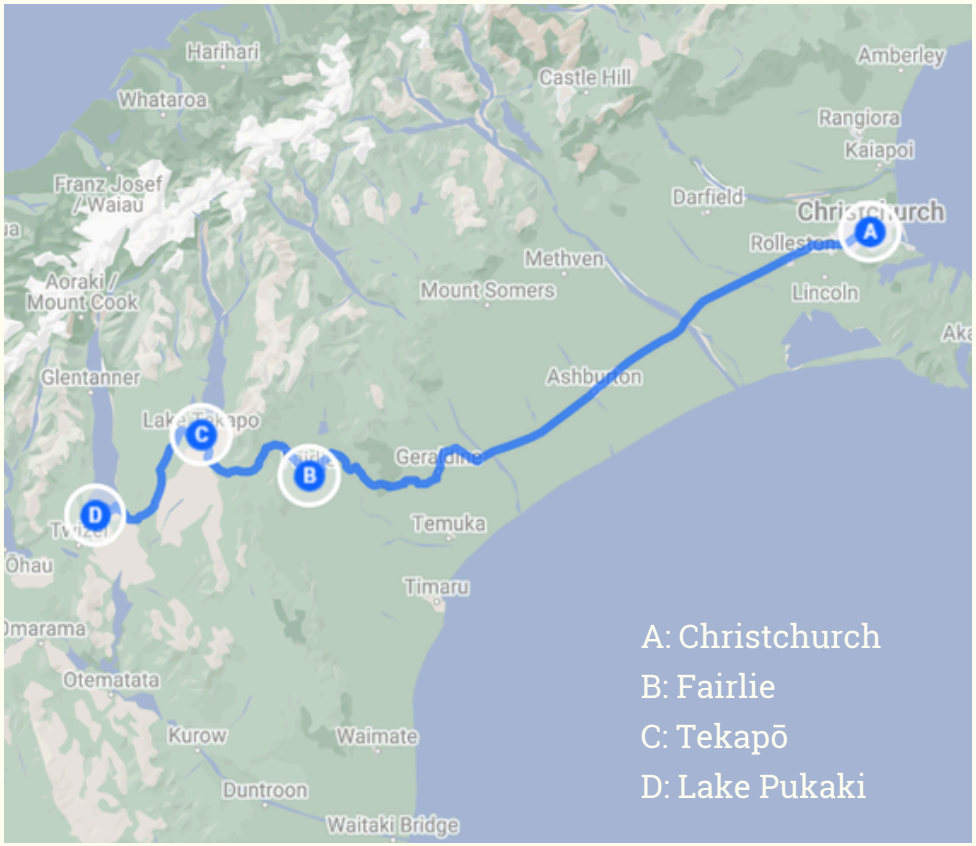


There's lots to see and explore in Christchurch City if you have the time! The Banks Peninsula and Akaroa are beautiful and definitely worth visiting.

If staying at Sumner Beach, make sure you check for freedom camping signs and follow the regulations - they are very strict and will fine you if you do not comply. Use the Rankers or CamperMate apps for more campsites.

Start	Christchurch
Must - dos	**Swim with dolphins in Akaroa** $210 per person (check Grabone for discounts) blackcat.co.nz
Optional	**Hot Air Balloons** approx $250 per person ballooningcanterbury.com **Explore the CBD** and walk along the Avon river
Driving time	2 hrs- 100 km
Eat at	**Riverside Market** - located in the Christchurch CBD with lots of restaurants to choose from **Sign of the Kiwi cafe and bar**
Stay at	**Okains Bay Campground** (on Banks Peninsula) - $15 each, or **Sumner Beach** (near Christchurch city) freedom camping
Finish	Christchurch

DAY 2-3: TEKAPŌ



Depending on the weather, you may want to spend one or two days in Tekapō. On the second night, stay at Lake Pukaki so that you can head to Mt Cook in the morning.

Stock up with any groceries that you need at 4 Square in Tekapō, as there are no supermarkets in Mt Cook. Also fill up your car with fuel.

Start	Christchurch
Must - dos	**Explore the lupin fields** **Church of the Good Shepherd**
Optional	**Mt St John Hike** - 3 hrs loop walk or 1 hr return to the observatory **Dark Sky Observatory** - Tekapō is one of the only night sky reserves in the world - with the best stars. Visit the observatory on a clear night to learn more **Tekapō Hot Springs** $35 each
Driving time	3 hrs- 225 km (Day 2) 30 mins - 50 km (Day 3)
Eat at	**Fairlie Bakery** - break up the driving and stop for an award winning pie in Fairlie
Stay at	**Lake Alexandria** freedom camping (Day 2) **Lake Pukaki** freedom camping (Day 3)
Finish	Lake Pukaki

TEKAPŌ





The lupin season is different every year, but generally from late Nov to early Dec. Find lupins on the Tekapo lakefront, or drive along Godley Heads Road for some more flower fields.

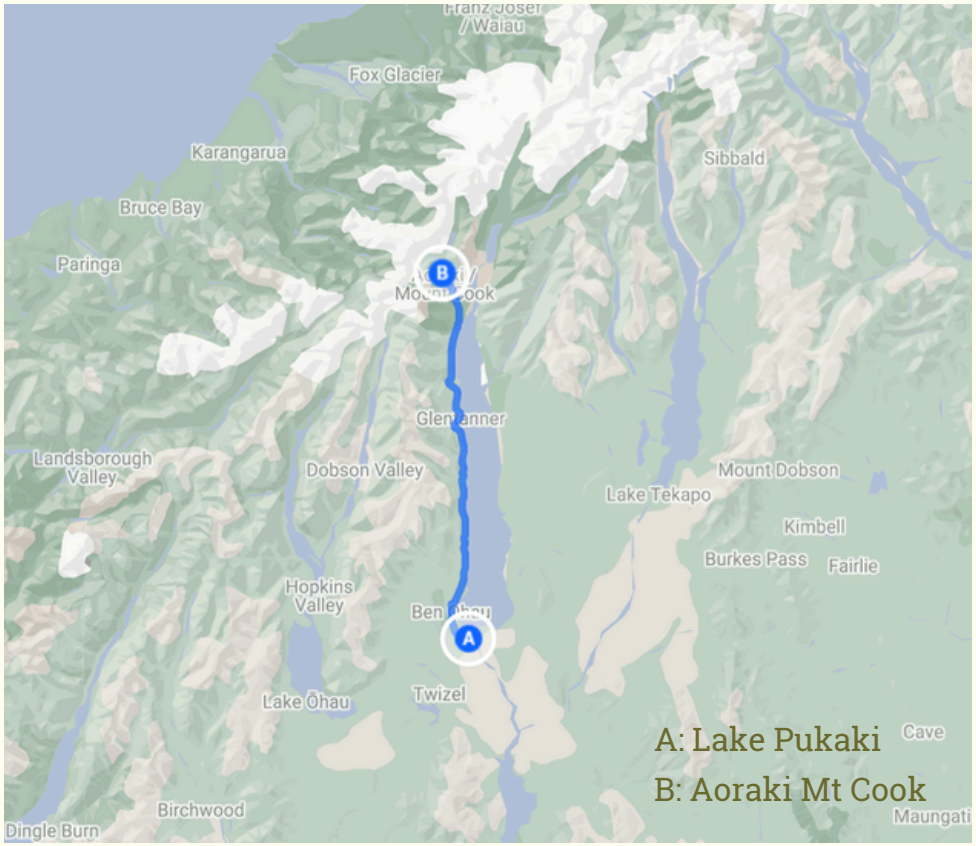


The iconic Church of the Good Shepherd sits on the shores of Lake Tekapo. The stone church is worth a visit and you can also go inside during opening hours.



The Mt John Summit Track starts behind Tekapo Springs and winds up the hill to the Mt St John observatory. It is often windy at the summit. You can also drive if to the observatory for views over the lake.

DAY 4: AORAKI MT COOK



Take your time with the Aoraki Mt Cook region and enjoy some of the most beautiful scenery you'll encounter on your trip. You will definitely need your camera!

Spend 1 - 2 nights here and take it slow to make sure you really get to appreciate the mountains and the lake. Finish your second day in Wānaka (Day 5).

Start	Lake Pukaki
Must - dos	**Hooker Valley Walk** (3 hrs return) **Tasman Glacier Walk** (1 hr return) **Lake Pukaki Viewpoint**
Optional	**Mueller Hut** - 4 hrs, 6 km one way. $45 each to stay at the hut **Sealy Tarns** - 2 hrs, 3 km one way **Scenic Flight** $229+ each mtcookskiplanes.com **Sky Diving** with Aoraki Sky Dive - $450+ each **Glacier Explorers Boat Trip** - $165 each glentanner.co.nz
Driving time	1 hour - 60 kms
Eat at	**The Hermitage** - with serveral restaurants and a cafe/bar, the Hermitage has incredible views
Stay at	**White Horse Hill** DOC camp site - $15 each. Book online.
Finish	Aoraki Mt Cook

DAY 5: MACKENZIE

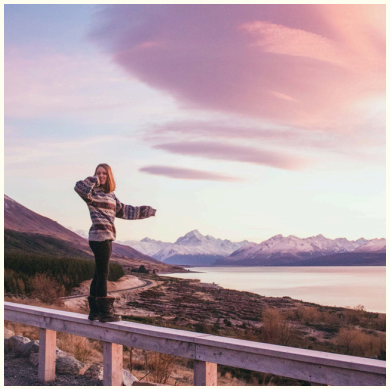


Spend the morning in Aoraki Mt Cook and when you have finished exploring region, drive down to the Wānaka region with a few stops on the way.

Stay at Albert Town Campground near Wānaka (closer to Roy's Peak) or Kidds Bush Reserve Campground near Lake Hāwea (closer to Isthmus Peak) depending on what you would like to do the following day.

Start	Aoraki Mt Cook
Must - dos	**Ōmarama Clay Cliffs** **Lindis Pass Lookout**
Optional	**Benmore Peninsula Walk** - 1.5 hrs loop - 4 km **Hot Tubs Ōmarama** - $120 for 2 people - 90 minutes. Book online.
Driving time	2.5 hours - 210 km (to Wānaka) 3 hrs - 240 km (to Hāwea)
Eat at	**Wānaka** town has a lot of options for food!
Stay at	**Albert Town Campground** $7-10 each. Pay cash on arrival, or **Kidds Bush Reserve Campground** DOC $10 each. Book online.
Finish	Wānaka or Hāwea

AORAKI MT COOK & MACKENZIE



The drive to Aoraki Mt Cook is spectacular, with several viewpoints to pull over and look at Lake Pukaki and the surrounding mountains.



Hooker Valley is a must-do. The track. It is 10km or 3 hours return, mostly flat, over swing bridges and boardwalk. Allow extra time as there are so many photo opportunities!



The Omarama Clay Cliffs are a unique location. It is 20 minutes from the main road, but well worth it if you have time. Entry is $5 per vehicle, so take cash with you.

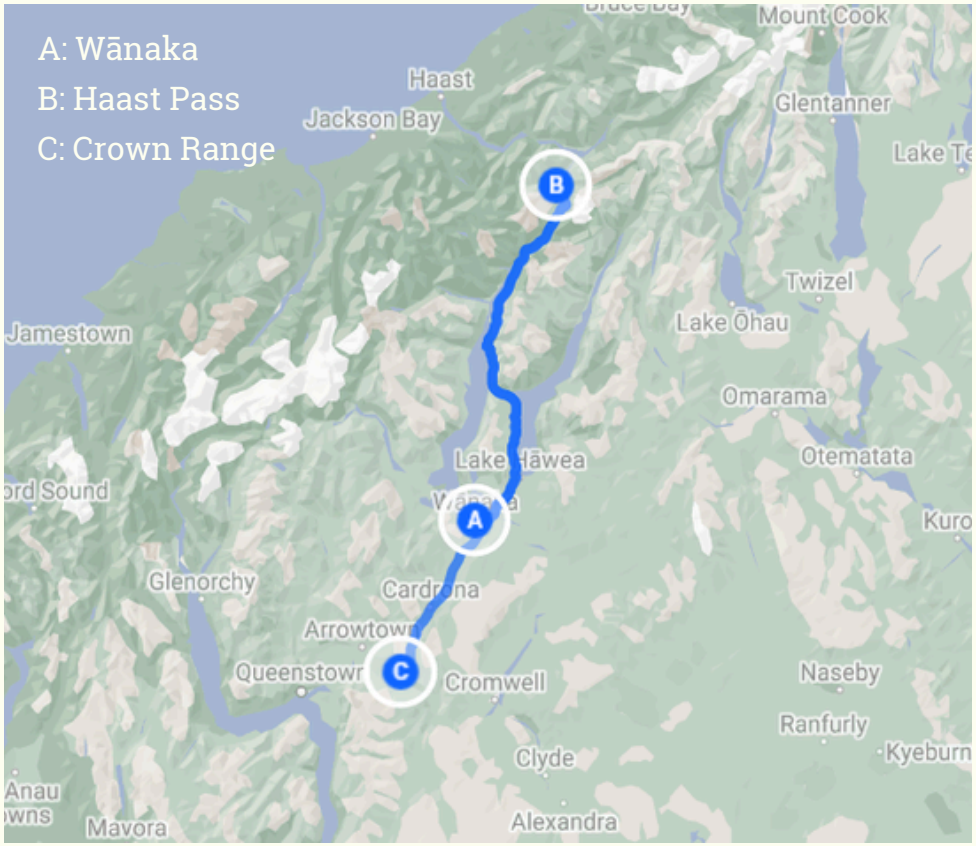


The Blue Lakes and Tasman Glacier walks are 1hr return. Take the track towards the lake if you want to get close to any of the icebergs.



The drive from Aoraki Mt Cook to Wānaka goes through Lindis Pass. Stop at the view points for to look out over the valley.

DAY 6-7: WĀNAKA & HAAST PASS



Spend a full day hiking Roy's Peak or Isthmus Peak and the next day relaxing or exploring Haast Pass.

Wānaka is a great place to use the laundromat, you can also have $5 showers at the Caltex petrol station.

Stay at the Crown Range lookout on Day 7 for gorgeous views over Queenstown!

Start	Wānaka or Hāwea
Must - dos	**Roys' Peak** or **Isthmus Peak -** 16 km return, approx 6-7 hours - full day hike
Optional	**Blue Pools** in Haast Pass - 1 hr, 1.5 km return **Thunder Creek Falls** in Haast Pass **Fantail Falls** in Haast Pass **Diamond Lake** in Wānaka - 3 hrs, 7 km loop **Mt Iron** in Wānaka - 1.5 hrs, 4.5 km
Driving time	1.5 hrs - 130 kms (over two days)
Eat at	**Cardrona Hotel** for a drink and an Instagram photo!
Stay at	**Albert Town Campground** $7-10 each. Pay cash on arrival, or **Kidds Bush Reserve Campground** DOC $10 each. Book online. **Crown Range Lookout** freedom camping (Day 7)
Finish	Crown Range, Queenstown

WĀNAKA & HAAST PASS





Roy's Peak (top) and Isthmus Peak (bottom) are the two best walks in the Wānaka region. They are similar length and altitude at 16 km return and 1400 m elevation. Roy's Peak is best for sunrise and Isthmus Peak is best for sunset. Whatever time of day you do the hike, ensure that you bring lots of water, sunscreen and a jacket, as the tracks are exposed and it can be very hot or very cold!

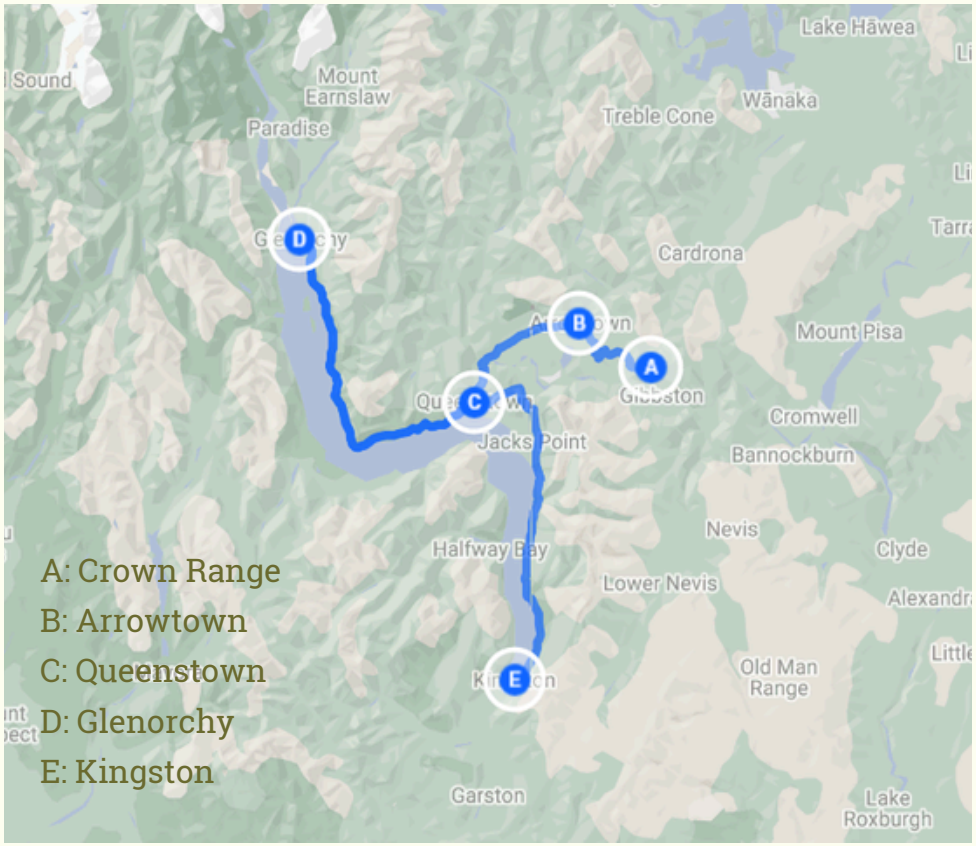


Thunder Creek Falls and Fantail Falls in Haast Pass are a short 5 minute walk from the road to the viewpoint.



The Blue Pools are some of the clearest and bluest water. It's a short 1 hour or 1.5 km return walk. It's a good spot for a swim but watch out for the pesky sandflies!

DAY 8-9: QUEENSTOWN



Two days to explore the Queenstown region - these can be split up depending on the weather forecast at Milford Sound. This list of things-to-do is not extensive - check out the Roady app or other blog posts for more activities, tours or food & drink.

There is no freedom camping in central Queenstown - stay at the Top 10 campground if you're ready for a shower!

Stay in Kingston before driving to Milford Sound to break up the longer drive.

Start	Crown Range
Must - dos	**Road to Glenorchy** **Bob's Cove** **Moke Lake**
Optional	**TSS Earnslaw** **Arrowtown Historic Town** **Onsen Hot Pools** - $145 for 2 people. 60 minutes. Book Online **Lake Alta Walk** **Queenstown Hill gondola** and **luge**
Driving time	2.5 hrs - 150 kms (over two days)
Eat at	**Ferg Burger** for the highly rated burgers and bakery! **Stratosfare** at the top of the luge with views over Queenstown
Stay at	**Moke Lake** DOC Campsite $15 each. No booking required, or **Queenstown Top 10** campground $55 per site. Book Online. **Kingston Lake** freedom camping.
Finish	Kingston

QUEENSTOWN & GLENORCHY





In Queenstown, you can book a cruise on Lake Wakatipu on the TSS Earnslaw. You can see the engine room and enjoy the scenic ride. $80 per adult.



The red Glenorchy boat shed and wharf are iconic, wear light or bright colours for the best photos - don't wear black!



Bob's Cove is a great stop on the road to Glenorchy - a 40 minute return walk takes you to this beautiful wharf and stunning blue water - perfect for a hot summer's day.

DAY 10-11: MILFORD SOUND



These suggestions are for Milford Sound - but the Doubtful Sound Cruise is another great alternative!

Make sure you stock up with groceries and fuel in Te Anau, as it is the last stop before Milford Sound!

Start	Kingston
Must - dos	**Milford Sound Cruise** - Nature Cruise with Southern Discoveries $100 each **Milford Sound Foreshore Swing** **Lake Marian** - 3 hrs, 6 km return
Optional	**Underwater observatory** **Kayak in Milford Sound -** $140+ each, 2 hr+ tour **Key Summit** - 3 hrs, 6 km return **Mirror Lakes** **Eglington Valley Lookout**
Driving time	3 hrs - 240 km (Day 10)
Eat at	**Pio Pio Restaurant** - the only restaurant in Milford Sound - $$$
Stay at	**Milford Sound Lodge** $70 per site (Day 10), or **Cascade Creek** DOC campground $15 each. Book Online. (Day 10) **Henry Creek Lake** DOC campground $15 each. Book Online. (Day 11)
Finish	Milford Sound

MILFORD SOUND



A cruise is the best way to experience the fiord encounter the wildlife. Book a tour with Southern Discoveries to visit the underwater observatory and see the underwater world too!



The drive to Milford Sound is spectactular. There are multiple viewpoints and you pass through the Homer Tunnel. Look out for cheeky kea - NZ's alpine parrot.



Lake Marian is an incredible hike, although the track is rocks and steep in parts. It is 6 km return and 700 m elevation. Allow 3 hours return.



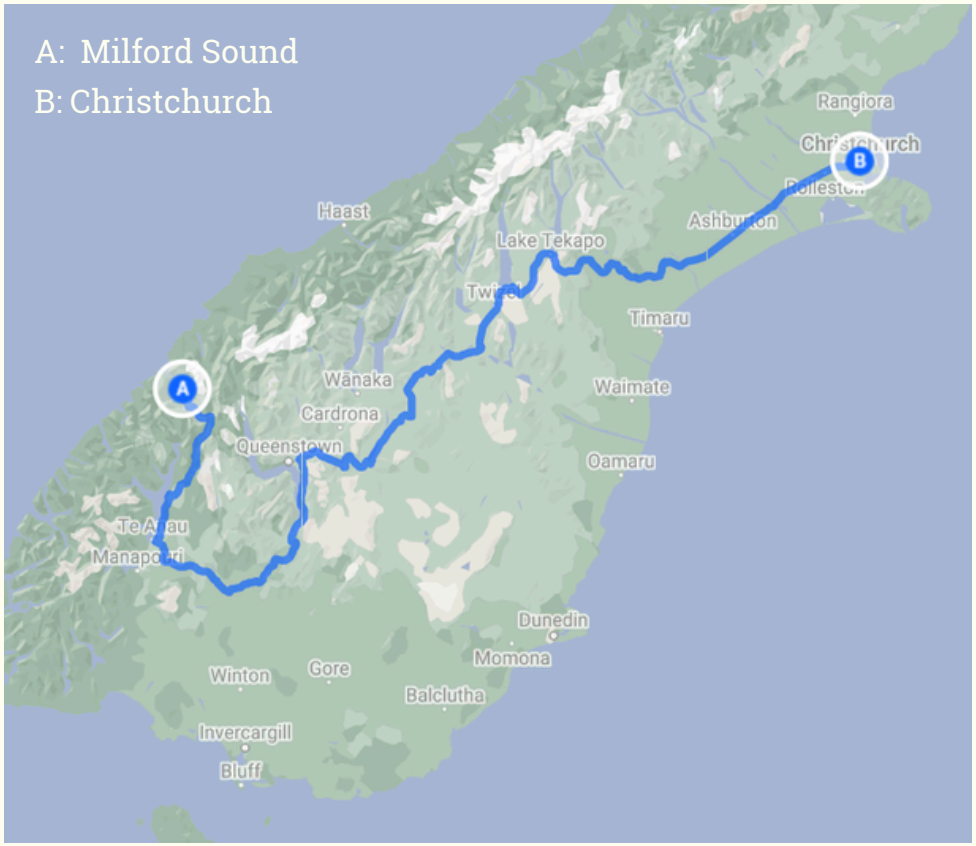
Follow the foreshore track to find the iconic Milford Sound swing with views of Mitre Peak.

Bring some bug spray to keep away the sandflies!



The key summit track forms part of the Routeburn Great Walk and is a well maintained track. It is 6 km return, but only worth it in good weather, to see the mountains all around.

DAY 12-14: MILFORD SOUND



Start	Milford Sound
Driving Time	9 hours - 760 km (over three days)
Finish	Christchurch

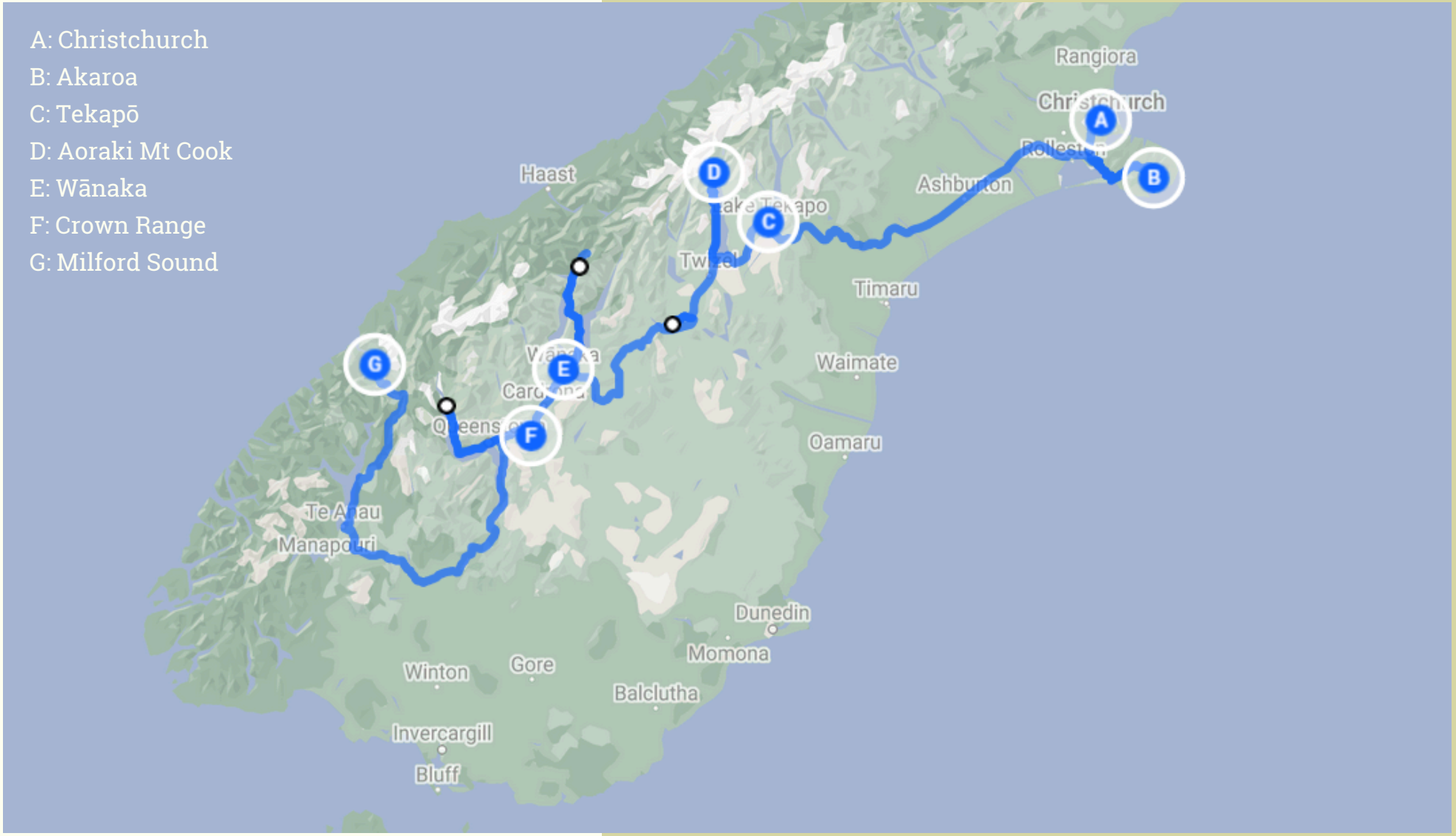
Retrace your steps from Milford Sound all the way back to Christchurch. Break up the trip and do any activities or walks that you missed out on the way down. Use the Roady app for any new activities you're interested in.

Stay at one of the same campsites or use the CamperMate and Rankers apps to find affordable or free campsites.

Make sure you share the driving and rest up in between!

TRIP OVERVIEW

A: Christchurch
B: Akaroa
C: Tekapō
D: Aoraki Mt Cook
E: Wānaka
F: Crown Range
G: Milford Sound





WANT MORE?

Oh hey, I'm Abigail Hannah and I'm obsessed with travelling New Zealand. I have been exploring every corner of the country for the last 7 years...and I'm not done yet. Check out some of these epic resources:

- Aotearoa Adventures: The New Zealand Travel Podcast
- My NZ Map & Guide
- 1-on-1 travel consult (60 min call)
- Itinerary review
- Personalised itinerary



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